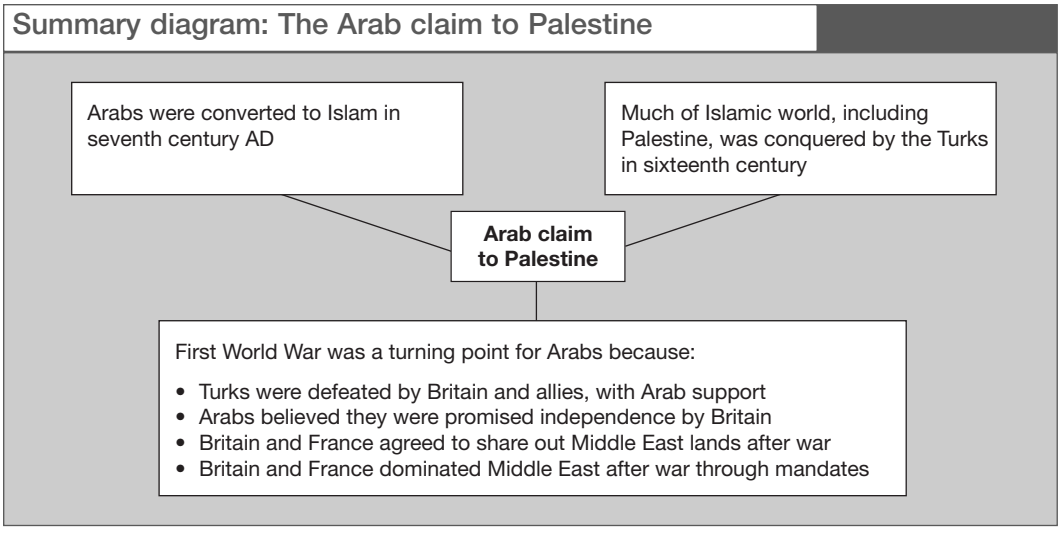


3 | British Rule in Palestine 1919–39

Key question
Why were Palestinian Arabs angry about Jews immigrating to Palestine after the First World War?

In 1917 British troops entered Jerusalem, the capital of Palestine, driving out the Turks. Two years later Britain was given a mandate to govern Palestine and, for the next 30 years, the British government was to rule the country. In 1922 the League of Nations confirmed that:

> Britain shall be responsible for placing the country under such political, administrative and economic conditions as will secure the establishment of the Jewish national home and the development of self-governing institutions, and also for safeguarding the civil and religious rights of all the inhabitants of Palestine no matter what their race or religion.

The Arabs of Palestine felt that they had simply exchanged Turkish rulers for British ones. Like the Arabs of Syria and Iraq, they were frustrated and disappointed that they had not been given their independence. They were even more angered by increasing Jewish immigration and the fact that Jews were buying land in 'their' country. Much of the land was bought from Arab landowners, many of whom were absentee landlords living in the cities. Furthermore, Arabs who had worked on the land, as tenants, were evicted because, very often, only Jews were employed to work on Jewish farms. The Jews only bought land in a few areas of Palestine but, in these areas, the Arabs claimed they were being driven out. They also accused the British of being pro-Zionist. The British High Commissioner in Palestine, Sir Herbert Samuel, was Jewish. To the Arabs, the British seemed to be favouring the Jews.

At the Paris peace conference, held at Versailles, in 1919, the British Zionist, Chaim Weizmann was asked what was meant by a Jewish national home. He replied: 'To make Palestine as Jewish as England is English'. But he did not speak openly of a Jewish